

Sweden Itinerary

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Some of the best travel days arrive uninvited. **18th August** began with the kind of mistake that ought to ruin a country crossing — *we had left our passports back at the Copenhagen hostel* — and ended in a library in Lund where I cried, very quietly, about a university I had once wanted to attend. Sweden, in one long, generous day, gave us back something we hadn't realised we'd lost.

Day 1: 18th August

The Øresund Bridge & a Border Officer Who Just Sighed

We boarded the train at **København H** for the 35-minute ride to **Malmö** — 7.8 km of bridge over open water, then a tunnel under the shipping lane. Halfway across, we both reached for our document pouches at the same time and made the same small, terrible sound. **The passports were still in the locker at the Copenhagen hostel.**

By the time the Swedish border officer reached our row, we had rehearsed three apologies and one mild panic. He looked at our driving licences, looked at us, looked at the bridge behind us, and quietly waved us through with the kind of *I-have-seen-worse* sigh that we now think of as Scandinavian-grade kindness. "*Don't do this on the way back.*" We did not.

The bridge under us, the passports two countries behind us, and a Swedish border officer choosing mercy. Some days the only thing standing between a great day and a ruined one is a single tired official deciding to be kind.

Day 1

Cardamom Buns, Lilla Torg & the Turning Torso

Malmö in mid-morning smelled of **cardamom buns** — *kardemummabullar*, the spiced cousin of the cinnamon bun, baked everywhere, sold by weight, warm enough to soften the butter still inside. We ate two each at a corner bakery before we'd seen anything else. That's the entire breakfast review.

From there we walked into **Lilla Torg** — the Little Square — a perfectly preserved 16th-century corner of timber-framed buildings and outdoor tables, every chair already taken on a warm August day. We didn't sit. We circled it twice, photographed it badly, and kept walking towards **Stortorget**, Malmö's grand main square, with its bronze equestrian statue of King Karl X Gustav, slightly intimidating, slightly underloved.

The walk to **Västra Hamnen** took us past the **Turning Torso** — Santiago Calatrava's residential skyscraper that twists 90 degrees from base to top. It's the kind of building you stop walking for. We stood under it, necks back, and tried to work out how it doesn't simply unscrew itself in a strong wind. Engineering as quiet showing-off. The waterfront beyond it was full of locals swimming, kayaking, eating ice creams on jetties — Scandinavian August doing what it does best.

Day 1

Malmö University & the Public Library

We walked through the **Malmö University** campus on our way back into town — modern, glass-fronted, set right against the harbour, students cycling between buildings as if commuting were a sport. The **Malmö Public Library** nearby — half a beautiful old red-brick castle, half a glass-cube

extension called "*The Calendar of Light*" — was open and free to wander. We sat for half an hour in a reading chair by the window, not really reading, mostly just being in a building that made being there feel like the point.

Day 1

Lund: A University Library & an Honest Cry

A 20-minute train took us to **Lund** — university town, 1020 AD, cobbled centre, cathedral with a 12th-century crypt. We walked the cathedral, walked the cobbles, and then walked into the **Lund University Library** — the open, public part — and that's where the day quietly turned.

I have spent a long time wanting to study at universities I will never study at. Lund is one of those. Standing under its high reading-room ceiling, watching actual students hunch over actual books, I felt — sharply, and without warning — the old, familiar disappointment. *Sab ko sab nahi milta*. Not everyone gets everything. I told myself, out loud, in a corridor, that I was being too harsh on myself. I was. We sat on a bench outside for ten minutes. Then we got up.

And then a small reframe arrived, the way good ones do — not loud, just true. **A new chapter: I would visit, as a tourist, every university I had once dreamed of attending as a student.** Oxford. Cambridge. Harvard. Whatever the list grows to. Each one a soft "*I came anyway.*" Lund was the first. The library let me have the moment. Then it let me go.

Day 1

A Mexican Dinner & Sunset on the Øresund Bridge

Dinner back in Malmö was a **burrito** at a tiny Mexican spot near the station — unexpectedly excellent, with the kind of chilli salsa that makes you respect a place. Then the train back across the **Øresund Bridge** at sunset. Pink water on the right side, deep blue on the left, the wind turbines of the strait turning slowly, and Denmark appearing on the horizon as a thin grey strip with a city laid on top of it.

We crossed the same bridge twice in one day. Both passports back in our hands by night. A library moment quietly tucked into the inside pocket of the trip, where it still lives.

Must-Visit in Malmö & Lund (in One Day)

- **Cardamom buns:** Any bakery, by weight, warm. Two each, minimum.
- **Lilla Torg:** Don't sit, just walk through.
- **Turning Torso:** Calatrava's twisting tower; stand directly underneath it.
- **Västra Hamnen waterfront:** Swimmers, kayakers, golden-hour light.
- **Malmö Public Library:** "Calendar of Light" — read a chapter for free.
- **Lund Cathedral & crypt:** 12th century, the giant Finn legend.
- **Lund University Library:** Even if you didn't study here. Especially if you didn't.
- **Øresund Bridge at sunset:** Pink right, blue left, Denmark on the horizon.

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